Production document

Playtest Plan

When to test, who to test with, how to run a session, what to measure, the questions to ask, and how to turn feedback into changes.

Applies to	Episode 1 in detail · reused for every episode
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Contents

01 Goals

02 Test Rounds

03 Recruiting Testers

04 Running a Session

05 What to Measure

06 Playtest Logging

07 Questionnaire

08 Observer Sheet

09 Turning Feedback into Changes

01 Goals

Question	How we find out
Is it scary?	Observed reactions, self-reported scares, where players hesitate or retreat
Is it clear?	Where players get lost or stuck; whether they can explain the story afterwards
Is it the right length?	Time per act against the beat sheet targets (1 h 35 – 1 h 55 total)
Is it fair?	Deaths per area, causes of deaths, frustration moments
Does it run?	Frame rate, loading time and crashes on testers' own computers and browsers
Is it respectful and accurate?	Sessions with Cambodian players and the cultural advisor

02 Test Rounds

Round	Build	Testers	Focus
R0 · Self	Every week	You	Play the whole episode start to finish; note anything broken or boring.
R1 · Greybox	End of Phase 2	3–5	Pacing, clarity, length, whether it is scary with placeholder shapes. Complete the greybox checklist (beat sheet section 8).
R2 · Systems	End of Phase 3	3–5	Controls, the satchel and sketchbook, lamp and resources, AI fairness, checkpoints.
R3 · Alpha	Mid Phase 4	5–8	Atmosphere, sound, readability in the dark, performance on varied hardware.
R4 · Release candidate	Phase 5	8–12	Final polish, bugs, browser coverage, cultural review, first impressions.

Use different testers in each round where possible: fresh eyes reveal confusion that returning testers no longer notice.

03 Recruiting Testers

Group	Why	Share of testers
Horror game players	The core audience; they know the genre's conventions	About half
Occasional players	Reveal control and clarity problems	About a quarter
Cambodian players	Cultural accuracy, language, emotional resonance	At least two per round from R3
Different hardware	Integrated-graphics laptops, Macs, older PCs; Chrome, Edge, Firefox, Safari	Mix across all groups

- Friends of friends are better than close friends, who tend to be kind rather than honest.
- Communities: local game-developer groups, university game clubs, Cambodian student associations, horror-game forums (for remote tests).
- Ask for consent to observe or record, explain what is collected, and let testers stop at any time. Warn testers that the game contains horror themes and depictions of death and grief.

04 Running a Session

Step	Time	What to do
1 · Welcome	5 min	Explain that you are testing the game, not them; there are no wrong answers; consent and content warning; headphones on.
2 · Play	90–120 min	Say nothing and do not help. Observe and take notes on the observer sheet. Only step in if they are stuck for more than 5 minutes; note it.
3 · Questionnaire	10 min	The questions in section 7, filled in alone before talking.
4 · Interview	10–15 min	Ask them to retell the story; ask about the scariest moment, the most confusing moment, and what they would change.
5 · Thank	—	Credit testers in the game if they wish.

REMOTE SESSIONS

Testers play the web build at home while sharing their screen and webcam in a video call, or send a recording afterwards. The playtest log (section 6) fills in what you cannot see.

05 What to Measure

Metric	Target (Episode 1)	Red flag
Total time	1 h 35 – 1 h 55	Under 1 h 15 or over 2 h 20
Time per act	Prologue 10 · Act I 30 · Act II 35 · Act III 30 min	Any act 50% over target
Stuck moments	None longer than 3 min	Any stuck for 5+ min
Catches per area	Walker 0–1 · roamer 1–3 · ritual 0–1	4+ catches in one area
Scares reported	At least 2 strong moments	"Never scared"
Story understanding	Can explain the pact, the seventh night and the fourth name	Cannot explain why Sora is in danger
Optional content	Half of testers open the shed; average 3 of 5 lore notes	Almost nobody finds the shed
Performance	30+ fps on integrated graphics at 720p	Below 25 fps, long hitches, crashes

06 Playtest Logging

Development and playtest builds keep a local event log that testers can export at the end with one button. It is not sent anywhere automatically.

Logged	Detail
Beats and checkpoints	Time each beat starts (P01…R05), so time per act is exact
Catches	Which entity, where (position) and when
Hints	Which control hints appeared, and how long before the action was performed
Resources	Oil level over time, matches used, times the lamp ran dry
Optional content	Shed opened, lore notes found, choice made at dawn
Performance	FPS once per second, area load times, browser, graphics API (WebGPU or WebGL2), GPU name if available

No personal data is recorded. Release builds disable the log unless the player turns it on to report a bug.

07 Questionnaire

#	Question	Answer type
1	How scary was the episode overall?	1 (not at all) – 5 (very)
2	What was the scariest moment?	Free text
3	Was there a moment you didn't know what to do? Where?	Yes/no + free text
4	In your own words, what is happening to Sora and why?	Free text
5	How did you feel about Yay Mey, Vuthy and Uncle Sok?	Free text
6	Did the controls feel comfortable? Anything awkward?	1–5 + free text
7	Did you understand the lamp, incense and thread duties?	1–5
8	Was the length right?	Too short · right · too long
9	Was anything unfair or frustrating?	Free text
10	How much did you want to play Episode 2?	1–5
11	(Cambodian testers) Did anything feel inaccurate, disrespectful or especially true to life?	Free text
12	Computer, browser, and did it run smoothly?	Free text

08 Observer Sheet

Time	Beat	What the player did or said	Type

Types: **S** scared (jump, lean back, sound) · **C** confused · **F** frustrated · **B** bored · **D** delight · **X** bug.

09 Turning Feedback into Changes

Severity	Definition	Action
Critical	Blocks progress, crashes, or culturally harmful	Fix before the next round
High	Most testers confused, stuck or frustrated at the same point	Fix before the next round
Medium	Some testers affected; pacing or clarity issue	Fix if time allows; retest
Low	One tester's preference	Note; act if it recurs

- **Watch what players do more than what they say.** If three people walk past the shed, the shed needs a better hint, even if nobody mentions it.
- **Look for patterns.** One person stuck is a data point; three people stuck in the same place is a design problem.
- **Fix the cause, not the symptom.** If players miss the drawer key, improve the gramophone clue rather than adding an arrow.
- After each round, write a one-page summary: top five problems, decisions made, and what to retest.